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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Ahmedabad terror attack that killed 56: 18 yrs on, HC upholds death sentence for 38

Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, July 7

THE GUJARAT High Court on Tuesday upheld the sentence awarded by a special trial court four years ago in the 2008 Ahmedabad serial blasts case, confirming the death penalty for 38 of the 49 convicted and life imprisonment for the remaining 11. The blasts on July 26, 2008, had killed 56 people and injured over 200.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* after the verdict, Special Public Prosecutor in the case, Mitesh Amin, said this is the first instance in the country where a high court has simultaneously confirmed death sentences for as many as 38 people.

The prosecution had contended during the trial that the accused were associated with Indian Mujahideen, an offshoot of the banned outfit SIMI, and had planned the blasts as “revenge” for the 2002 post-Godhra riots in Gujarat and to overthrow an elected government.

A Division Bench, comprising Justices A Y Kogje and Samir Dave, also dismissed the appeals filed by the accused against the trial court’s judgment of February 2022. The



As many as 22 bombs went off in Ahmedabad on July 26, 2008. FILE

INSIDE PAGE 9
APPROPRIATE, FAIR, JUST DECISION, SAY FAMILIES OF VICTIMS

High Court directed the state government to pay compensation to the victims in the case — Rs 10 lakh each in cases of death, Rs 5 lakh for grievous injury and Rs 1 lakh for minor injury — by March 2027.

Among those facing the death row, at least 14 are from Gujarat, followed by eight from UP, six from Maharashtra, five from MP, two each from Kerala and Karnataka, and one from Hyderabad.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM MEETS INDONESIA PRESIDENT, ADDRESSES PARLIAMENT

Missiles, minerals and port: Delhi, Jakarta seal key deals

Eye on China, Modi says India on path of development, not expansionism

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA AND Indonesia signed pacts on the supply of BrahMos and Air-to-Air missiles, along with cooperation on critical minerals and rare earths, maritime security, and space and agriculture as Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto in Jakarta on Tuesday.

Modi also addressed the Indonesian Parliament as part of his two-day visit, making a thinly veiled reference to China’s assertive behaviour in the Indo-Pacific. “India is a strong advocate of a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific. India believes in freedom of navigation in the Indo-Pacific... India is a nation that follows the path of development, not

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with President Prabowo Subianto after being conferred the Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia, the country’s highest civilian honour, in Jakarta, Tuesday. PTI
I AM A GREAT ADMIRER OF PM MODI: SUBIANTO PAGE 6

On table: Two BrahMos missile batteries worth \$200 million

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA IS set to supply Indonesia with two batteries of BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles valued at \$200 million as part of several landmark defence agreements signed between the two countries on Tuesday, including Astra air-to-air missile systems, major defence technology transfer, and maritime security cooperation, officials told *The Indian Express*.

The BrahMos missile has been operationalised in India across all the three defence services and played a key role in striking designated targets inside Pakistan during Operation Sindoor.

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Delhi and Jakarta seal series of key deals

expansionism,” he said.

Modi said, “In recent years, the relationship between India and Indonesia has acquired renewed energy, greater confidence, and deeper strategic depth. Our Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, established in 2018, is reaching new heights today. We are making significant strides across every domain of cooperation, including development, security, technology, culture, and education. I am confident that today marks the beginning of a golden new chapter in the India-Indonesia partnership.”

The Indonesian President also awarded PM Modi the Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia “Medal of Honour”, the country’s highest civilian honour for individuals who have rendered exceptional service to its unity, continuity and prosperity.

Modi, who is on a three-nation trip from July 6 to 11 during which he will also visit Australia and New Zealand, said, “The growing trust between our two countries is strengthening our cooperation in defence, security, and the maritime domain. Today, we agreed to further enhance collaboration in defence exchanges, disaster management, and industrial cooperation.”

According to a joint state-Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

ment issued by both countries, both leaders “agreed to further strengthen cooperation and enhance engagements in both traditional and emerging areas of defence cooperation”. It said that “they welcomed the elevation of defence cooperation, including through cooperation on BrahMos Missile System, and the Air-to-Air Missile Cooperation Agreement”.

The statement quoted Modi as saying that the Coast Guards of the two countries “will now work together to enhance maritime safety and security in the Indian Ocean”. “As two close maritime nations, we have also decided to deepen our cooperation in the blue economy, port development, and maritime trade,” Modi said.

According to the joint statement, President Prabowo “welcomed India’s interest in partnering on the integrated development of the Sabang Port”.

“Both leaders recognised that such a partnership -- spanning cruise and marine-tourism facilities, maritime industries (ship-repair and shipbuilding), and shore-based services supporting offshore energy activities in the Andaman Sea -- would foster institutional, physical, digital and flow of people and commodities between Andaman and Nicobar Islands of

India and Provinces in Sumatra Island, that contribute to generating investment, employment, transfer of technology and shared regional prosperity,” the statement said.

Sabang port is located at the northwestern entrance to the Strait of Malacca, a critical global maritime corridor through which roughly 25 to 40 per cent of global seaborne trade passes. It lies just 160 kilometres, or less than 100 nautical miles, from India’s upcoming trans-shipment hub at Great Nicobar.

As the two sides signed pacts on rare earth and critical minerals, Modi said, “We have also concluded an important agreement to strengthen supply chain resilience in the areas of critical minerals and steel. In addition, our companies are embarking on a new phase of partnership in stainless steel and rare earth magnets.”

Indonesia dominates the global critical minerals sector, commanding roughly 21% of the world’s nickel reserves and ranking among the top global producers of copper, bauxite, and tin.

The other pacts signed between the two sides included the opening of an IIM Bangalore campus in Indonesia, supply of medicines and medical products to Indonesia, telecom technology including wireless and

quantum systems, and conservation and restoration of the Prambanan temple complex in Yogyakarta, among others.

“Tomorrow, I will have the privilege of joining President Prabowo in Yogyakarta to launch the conservation project for the Prambanan Temple. More than 1,000 years old, the Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of the shared cultural heritage of India and Indonesia,” Modi said.

On global issues, Modi said that there “is strong synergy in our respective outlooks on the Indo-Pacific” and that “India has always attached special importance to ASEAN centrality”.

“In this period of global turbulence, India believes that the role of dialogue and diplomacy has become more important than ever before. On the issue of Palestine, we continue to support a Two-State Solution and the pursuit of lasting peace,” he said.

On Monday, as Modi landed in Jakarta, he was received at the airport by President Prabowo and four ministers, including the Foreign Minister, Minister of Palace Affairs and Cabinet Secretary. This is the Prime Minister’s fourth visit to Indonesia and his first bilateral visit since ties were elevated to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in May 2018.

Ahmedabad blasts

As many as 22 bombs went off in Ahmedabad on July 26, 2008, at various spots, including the state government-run civil hospital, the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation-run LG Hospital, on buses, parked bicycles, in cars and other places.

Two other bombs, at Kalol and Naroda, did not go off.

Earlier, a special court presided over by Special Judge A R Patel had held the criminal trial against 77 accused. It convicted 49, awarding death sentences to 38 and life terms to the other 11. The court acquitted 28 accused, giving them the benefit of the doubt. One of the accused in the case, Ayaz Saiyed, had turned approver.

The special court’s judgment was also a first in the country in terms of simultaneous death penalties awarded in a single case.

The trial was based on 35 cases -- 20 registered in Ahmedabad and 15 in Surat, where similar bombs, which did not detonate, were found after the Ahmedabad blasts.

The 49 convicts were found guilty under various provisions of the Indian Penal Code, the Explosive Substances Act, the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

Welcoming the High Court judgment, one of the victims in the case, Yash Vyas (28), said, “The judgment is appropriate. My father, my brother and many others were killed in the blasts.”

Vyas was just eight when an explosion outside the Trauma Centre of the Civil Hospital killed his father Dushyant, a hospital employee, and elder brother Rohan. “The two of us

brothers were with our father to learn how to ride a bicycle in the open area there. We were about to return home when my father got a call seeking help for a patient reaching the Trauma Centre. We had reached the centre when the blast occurred. My father and brother died while I sustained injuries,” Vyas had said earlier.

Welcoming the High Court verdict as “historic,” Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi said the state government will comply with the court’s directions on providing compensation to victims.

An official press release quoted Sanghavi as saying, “With today’s verdict, justice has finally been delivered to the victims, their families, and the people of Gujarat. By upholding the trial court’s judgment, the Gujarat High Court has confirmed the death penalty for 38 terrorists and life imprisonment for 11 others, making this one of

the most significant judgments in the history of India’s judicial system.”

Sanghavi expressed gratitude to the High Court, the trial court and the investigation team in the case. “The investigating agencies deserve appreciation for their dedicated efforts over the years, ensuring the case was pursued without any legal lapses or compromise. The verdict sends a clear message that there is no place for terrorism or anti-national activities on Indian soil,” he said.

Among those present in the High Court Tuesday was former IPS officer Abhay Chudasama, who was part of the investigation team as Deputy Commissioner of Police at the Ahmedabad City Detection of Crime Branch.

Speaking to reporters, Chudasama said, “The judgment given by the Sessions court has been confirmed by the High Court, which means our investigation was right.”

BrahMos batteries

A BrahMos battery typically comprises four launchers and 12 ready-to-fire missiles, along with other equipment and vehicles, though the composition can vary between land-based regiments and coastal defence batteries.

With this deal, India is set to export the system to three countries, also including the Philippines and Vietnam, even as it holds talks with at least half-a-dozen other nations on the missile system.

The Philippines had procured three batteries of the weapon system from India in 2022. In May this year, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh officially confirmed at the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore that India had signed a deal with Vietnam for the sale of BrahMos missiles, and that a similar deal with Indonesia was in “final stages”.

New Delhi has been in talks with Jakarta over the sale of

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the missile system under a joint venture between the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Russia’s NPO Mashinostroyeniya.

The Indian Express had earlier reported that the finer details of the deal were discussed during the third India-Indonesia defence ministers’ dialogue, co-chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and his Indonesian counterpart Sjafrie Sjamsoeddin in New Delhi last November.

Brahmos Aerospace Private Ltd is also looking to export a compact next-gen version, BrahMos NG, to at least 10 countries, including South Africa and West Asian nations such as Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Egypt.

Work is also underway to extend the range of existing BrahMos missiles from 290 km to 500 km for land attacks, and to 400 km for ship attacks.

Ridge set to be revived in 4 yrs, says Shah; launches campaign to plant 70 lakh trees

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

A MEGA drive to plant 70 lakh trees in the Capital and a campaign to revive the Ridge were launched on Tuesday by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, among other initiatives, in the presence of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta to realise what he called “a vision of a greener and more sustainable Delhi”.

‘Mission 70 Lakh Plantation’ campaign, he said, has been launched in the Capital under Centre’s ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ initiative in 2024 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The Union Home Minister planted trees at the Central Ridge and Nanakpura Ridge, marking the beginning of the Delhi Ridge Rejuvenation Campaign.

He said that the Centre and Delhi government have resolved to develop 6,300 hectares of green Ridge area into forest land over the next four years and give legal protection to it to conserve its biodiversity, soil, water and Delhi’s environment.

Union Minister of Environment Bhopender Yadav and Union Minister Harsh Malhotra were also present at the event. Shah said the Ridge, first notified under the Indian Forest Act in 1994, had remained without a

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Union Home Minister Amit Shah, with LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, CM Rekha Gupta, Union Minister of Environment Bhopender Yadav, and Union Minister Harsh Malhotra in New Delhi Tuesday. ABHINAV SAHA

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the entire Ridge to turn it into the lungs of a green Delhi. "The Delhi government has taken a positive step in this direction and declared 5,000 hectares of this area as forest land," he said, adding that legal protection would help restore the area's biodiversity, soil and water systems.

"Many poisonous and thorny trees are visible in Delhi's Ridge area, which create an illusion of a green Delhi when seen, but are not favorable to our environment," Shah said.

He added, "Within three years, trees that live for more than 100 years such as peepal, banyan, neem, gular, arjun and jamun will be planted across

the entire Ridge to turn it into the lungs of a green Delhi.

Meanwhile, the mega plantation programme includes plantation of 20.01 lakh trees, 37.07 lakh shrubs and 92,960 bamboo saplings, along with free distribution of 12.04 lakh saplings to schools, Resident Welfare Associations, institutions and citizens to encourage Jan Bhagidari in environmental conservation, according to officials.

The Delhi government has launched the Green Drive Portal to promote tree plantation by providing free saplings, highlighted an official statement by the Ministry of Home Affairs, adding that "citizens

are encouraged to plant trees wherever land is available and contribute to realising the vision of a Green Delhi."

Shah also laid the foundation stone for the High-Security Prison at Narela, inaugurated the Automated Vehicle Testing Centre, inaugurated three new depots, and flagged off 300 electric buses in Delhi.

He said cow dung from Delhi's dairies will no longer flow directly into the Yamuna river. Shri Amit Shah said that an agreement will soon be signed with the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) to ensure that not even one kilogram of dung enters the Yamuna.

Four beneficiary states sign pact on Narmada outstanding dues

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

CHIEF MINISTERS of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Rajasthan signed an agreement on Tuesday relating to the settlement of outstanding dues of the Narmada Water Disputes Tribunal (NWDT) Award Projects.

The "historic agreement" was signed in the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil.

CMs Devendra Fadnavis (Maharashtra), Bhupendra Patel (Gujarat), Bhajan Lal Sharma (Rajasthan) and Dr. Mohan Yadav (Madhya Pradesh), along with senior officials from the Centre and the states, were present on the occasion.

The Centre had constituted the NWDT in 1969, which gave its Award in 1979. The NWDT Award specified the quantum of water that could be utilised by the four states, as well as determined their share of the net power produced at Navagam at Canal Head and River Bed Power Houses. While most issues were resolved after the Award's distribution, issues like dues pertaining to the cost-sharing of the Sardar Sarovar Project and the Indira

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(L-R) Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav, Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel, Union Minister of Jal Shakti C R Patil, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma during the Narmada agreement signing. PTI

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Sagar Project, Resettlement & Rehabilitation (R&R) Expenditure, Compensation for Submerged land, and the interest burden on borrowings during construction remained pending which are now resolved.

In a statement, the Ministry of Home Affairs said, "This agreement marks a historic milestone in resolving the long-standing disputes among the States of Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Maharashtra relating to cost-sharing arrangements for the construction of the Sardar Sarovar Project. Under the agreement, payments to be made towards the final settlement of pending dues have been resolved."

Commending Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, Shah said several historic initiatives have been undertaken to strengthen water security and promote cooperative federalism in the water sector.

"He [Amit Shah] said that the formation of double-engine governments in several States under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi has enhanced the ability to understand one another, reduced political differences, and accelerated the resolution of many long-pending disputes across the country," the statement said.

Shah also "appreciated the constructive cooperation" ex-

tended by the four state governments in building a broad consensus on this inter-State project.

"He [Shah] said that with the completion of the dam, water and electricity have reached every part of these States. He [Shah] further said that while the benefits accruing to Rajasthan may appear modest at first glance, the areas that have received Narmada waters have witnessed a transformation in (terms of) both the value of the land and the fortunes of the farmers," the statement said.

Shah also lauded Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil's role in resolving water-related issues.

PM ADDRESSES INDIAN DIASPORA

‘1.4 bn aspirations in motion’: Modi sums up India’s growth in Jakarta

Indonesia
President Prabowo
says he is a great
admirer of PM
Narendra Modi

Divya A
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA IS moving forward with the mantra of “reform, perform and transform”, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in Jakarta on Tuesday, underlining that self-reliance is a multiplying force not only for Indonesia but for the entire ASEAN region.

Speaking at a diaspora event in Jakarta, also attended by President Prabowo Subianto, Modi said: “India has carried out one reform after another. We have consistently performed, and that’s why the country is transforming today. We are moving forward with the mantra of reform, perform, and transform.”

In his address, Prabowo highlighted his “Indian DNA” and his great admiration for PM Modi. Modi said if he had to describe the speed and scale of In-



PM Narendra Modi with Indonesia’s President Prabowo Subianto during the Indian Community reception, in Jakarta. PTI

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dia’s growth in one line, he’d say “1.4 billion aspirations in motion”. “India is not just the world’s fastest-growing economy; it’s a nation with a billion-plus dreams in motion,” he said, adding that India’s economy is playing a major role in driving global growth.

“From energy to connectivity and chip manufacturing, India is unstoppable. Today’s

India is not just fulfilling its own dreams but also fulfilling those of every friendly nation. India walks on the mantra of ‘sabka saath, sabka vikas,’ Modi said.

“As India is modernising its ports, building new ships and exploring new sea routes to strengthen its maritime sector, Indonesia stands as our favourite friend ... Whether in Indonesia or India, our shared goal is de-

velopment. We cannot afford to wait or stop,” Modi said.

Addressing the gathering ahead of Modi, Prabowo said Indonesia draws inspiration from Indian democracy. “I don’t want to be involved in domestic Indian politics. I’m a friend of all Indians but I want to admit one thing and my close associates and colleagues will testify that I am a great admirer of Narendra

Modi ji. I’m not a professional politician. The proof that I’m not a professional politician is that I took part in five general elections. I lost four times... Even before I became President, I studied the policies of the Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) and because there are no copyright, I copied many of his policies. But, Prime Minister Modi graciously allowed me to copy his policies. So, I cannot be sued in any court,” Prabowo said.

Highlighting his “Indian DNA”, Prabowo, who was the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations in 2025, shared how gene testing confirmed his Indian DNA just before he visited India. “Whenever I hear Indian music, I find my body moving... my ministers and generals all like to dance and sing. Maybe most of them have Indian DNA also ... It’s true. Most of my ministers sing Indian songs really well,” he added.

On this, Modi said, “Your statement has touched the hearts of Indians. And this DNA is made of mutual trust, shared heritage, shared memories. The relationship between India and Indonesia is rooted in our shared civilisational heritage and the seas that connect us.”

Landslide hits Wayanad tunnel project days after Collector’s warning on soil pile, 3 killed

Shaju Philip & Nikhila Henry
*Meppadi (Wayanad),
Hyderabad, July 7*

DAYS AFTER the District Collector of Kerala’s Wayanad had called a halt to the construction of the Wayanad-Kozhikode twin tunnel project and directed that accumulated soil at the site be removed, a landslide struck the area on Tuesday, leaving three people dead and seven missing.

The incident took place in the Meenakshi area of the district, just 4 km away from Chooralmala, one of the two villages that were largely swept away by devastating landslides on July 30, 2024, which had killed around 300 people. The three victims are migrant workers identified as crane operator Chandra Bhan from Madhya Pradesh, civil foreman Bikash Kumar from Bihar and labourer Anmol from Jharkhand.

The construction work at the Wayanad side of the tunnel had been halted since June 20 following a direction from District Collector Meghashree D R, who is also the chairperson of the District Disaster Management Authority. However, around two dozen people, including workers, security staff and supervisors, remained at the site for the day-to-day management of the work site.

Before this, preparatory work

was underway for the construction of the tunnel. The work included cutting the hill into benched slopes, which were reinforced with a soil nail wall. As a result of this work, a large heap of soil had accumulated at the side of the proposed tunnel’s opening. The collector had called for construction to be stopped until the soil was removed. However, ministers and officials accused the contractors of not removing the soil in time, leading to the disaster.

Bhopal-based Dileep Buildcon, which is constructing the twin tunnels, said in a statement that it had followed all regulations and attributed the incident to “exceptionally heavy rainfall”.

In the landslide, a massive chunk of loose soil came down from the hill. Workers, who were at the site and on the road between the villages of Meppadi and Chooralmala, were buried under debris, which flowed down Meenkshi river, wiping out a masjid and a house nearby.

Eye witness Musthafa, who runs a teashop near the construction site, said, “The work had been stopped for around three weeks. However, heavy rain had caused the soil dumped from the construction work to come down on the road. Yesterday, the area witnessed heavy rain, and the road got covered with sludge. A few workers were



Debris flows down a river after the landslide in Wayanad on Tuesday. PTI
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cleaning the bridge by pumping water from a tanker truck. At around 11.05 am, we heard a frightening roar and in a few seconds, everything was over. A bus loaded with passengers had passed the bridge a few minutes before the tragedy.” Musthafa sustained a minor injury while trying to escape from the spot.

Rescue workers, including personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), state police, and the fire force, as well as volunteers, faced the uphill task of searching the

hilllock covered in sludge and debris. Little progress has been made in removing the sludge from the Meenakshi bridge, leaving people living in Chooralmala and nearby areas cut off.

After reviewing the situation at the headquarters of the state disaster management authority, Chief Minister V D Satheesan said contractors had been told to remove the soil, which had been left over after cutting down the hill and kept in a heap, from the site on June 20. “The Wayanad District Collector and the Dis-

aster Management Authority had given a direction in this regard. Later, the Public Works Minister had raised the same demand to the contractor, but they did not comply,” the CM said. He added the sludge from the site would be removed at the earliest.

Agriculture Minister and Kalpetta MLA T Siddique also blamed the contractor, claiming, “Unscientific dumping of loose soil at project site led to tragedy. This is not a natural landslide, but a man-made landslide.”

Kerala’s Minister for En-

vironment and Climate Change, Sunny Joseph, also told *The Indian Express* the District Collector had given standing instructions to remove the soil that was accumulating at the site. “The order was not considered, and the construction company went ahead with the tunnelling work,” he alleged. “This is a man-made disaster because the warning was ignored. We are seriously looking into the lapses that put lives in danger,” he added.

Dilip Buildcon said in a statement, “The incident occurred during an active monsoon spell, amid exceptionally heavy rainfall in Wayanad. The India Meteorological Department had issued warnings for heavy to very heavy rainfall across parts of Kerala, while preliminary data from the Kerala State Disaster Management Authority indicates that Wayanad received approximately 265 mm of rainfall in the preceding 24 hours — among the highest recorded in the district this monsoon season.”

“This is 9-10 times the rainfall of an average July day, and also well over one-third of Kerala’s average July rainfall occurring in just 24 hours. Wayanad, along with other hill districts of Kerala, has historically remained vulnerable to monsoon-induced landslides,” it added.

The statement further said, “The project is being executed in

strict compliance with all applicable engineering, safety and environmental approvals and protocols. Given its location in an ecologically sensitive region, the project is subject to multiple regulatory oversight and monitoring mechanisms, including supervision by the Supreme Court-appointed Central Empowered Committee, and all excavated material is handled in accordance with the approved methodology. With such additional and strict compliance procedures, the room for technical error remains very limited. We remain fully committed to cooperating with the probe and will continue to share verified information as it becomes available. Our focus remains on supporting rescue efforts and standing with affected families during this difficult time.”

Konkan Railway Corporation is the implementing agency for the project, which is expected to be completed in four years. Construction of the tube tunnels has been awarded to Bhopal-based Dilip Buildcon, while the approach roads and bridges in the project will be constructed by Kolkata-based Royal Construct.

Konkan Railway Corporation and Royal Construct did not respond to requests for comment. The proposed 8.11-km tunnel is estimated to cost around Rs 2,400 crore.

EXPRESS special

NEET-UG 2027 at 1,000 centres over 5-6 days; ‘top to bottom’ NTA revamp

Shyamal Yadav
New Delhi, July 7

THE NEET-UG for admission to undergraduate medical education will from next year be a computer-based test conducted across five-six days at around 1,000 centres in 500 cities, mainly government institutions such as Kendriya Vidyalayas, with around 5 lakh candidates to be accommodated each day, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Government is also set to overhaul the National Testing Agency (NTA), the nodal autonomous body that conducts NEET-UG apart from other entrance tests to higher educational institutions — a revamp that will cover the agency’s organisation, infrastructure, technology and processes, sources told this newspaper.

“We are going to change the entire organisation of the NTA, from top to bottom,” sources said, adding that the exercise is expected to be completed before October. There are around 150 posts sanctioned in the NTA.

These proposals by the Ministry of Education come in the



The exam will be conducted in 500 cities, with around 5 lakh candidates to be accommodated each day. FILE

wake of the paper leak that led to this year’s NEET-UG being held again, after the first exam on May 3, in which around 22 lakh candidates appeared, was cancelled, triggering outrage, protests and a CBI probe.

Sources said the move is based on recommendations of the high-powered seven-member committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan, constituted by the Centre in 2024 in the wake of a paper leak that year.

On May 15, while announcing the NEET-UG retest on June 21, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had said

that the exam, which has been a pen-and-paper exercise, would be computer-based from next year. Pradhan had said the switch was based on a recommendation of the Radhakrishnan committee — but the suggestion had not been implemented so far.

According to the plan for next year’s NEET-UG, sources said, most of the centres being identified are government institutions, including Kendriya Vidyalayas and Navodaya Vidyalayas, while “some reputed private institutions may also be made centres”.

Each of these centres will

accommodate around 500 candidates every day, sources said. A detailed notification, including shift timings, the list of test cities and other details, is expected to be issued after the proposed NTA revamp is completed.

Referring to allegations that only those down the chain, such as question-paper setters and translators, have been arrested so far in the latest paper leak, and not the main figures, sources said: “As far as criminal action is concerned, investigations are going on and no one will be spared if he or she has committed the crime.”

Recently, top officials from the Ministry of Education and the NTA appeared before the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports to brief members on the steps being taken to strengthen the entrance examination system.

Following the NEET-UG leak, *The Indian Express* investigated the status of cases linked to 45 major exam paper leaks over the past two decades in which each exam had at least 1 lakh candidates — it found that only two of these cases have led to convictions.

‘Appropriate, fair, just’: Families of those killed & injured in Ahmedabad blasts on HC verdict

Parimal A Dabhi & Leena Misra
Ahmedabad, July 7

YASH VYAS was just eight years old when he lost his father Dushyant and older brother Rohan in the bomb blasts that ripped through the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital’s trauma centre on July 26, 2008. He survived with injuries.

Welcoming the Gujarat High Court verdict, Vyas, 28, told *The Indian Express* on Tuesday, “The judgment is appropriate. My father, my brother and many others were killed in the blasts.” His father was an employee at the hospital and was at

work when he was killed.

Vyas earlier told this newspaper, “The two of us (he and his brother) were with our father to learn how to ride a bicycle in the open area there. We were about to return home when my father got a call seeking help for a patient in reaching the Trauma Centre. We reached the centre when the blast occurred.”

Nearly 22 bombs went off in a coordinated manner on that day, killing 56 people and injuring over 200. A special trial court had awarded death sentences to 38 of the 49 convicted persons in 2022, sentencing the rest to life imprisonment. The Gujarat High Court upheld the

lower court’s verdict on Tuesday while hearing an appeal challenging it.

Jashvant Patel (59) was among those who died at Ahmedabad Civil Hospital in the terror blast on July 26, 2008.

Patel was running a garage in the Asarva area and had gone to help the victims of the blasts that had taken place in various parts of the Ahmedabad city. When he was at the hospital a blast took place in front of the trauma centre.

His son, Amrish (49) runs the same garage and now lives in the Vastrapur area of the city.

Amrish said, “My father was part of a group of people in the



The Gujarat High Court on Tuesday. BHUPENDRA RANA

area who used to aid the patients at Civil Hospital. On learning of the blasts in the city, he went to the hospital, where

he was seriously injured. I got to know about his death nearly two hours after the blast.”

“My uncle was there at the

hospital when my father was injured. As there was chaos at Civil Hospital then, he was being taken to the nearby Rajasthan Hospital. However, he died on the way,” Amrish added.

He added, “It is good that the culprits have been punished by the High Court. So many people died.”

According to Amrish, at the relevant time, they were awarded compensation of around Rs 10 lakh by the Central and state governments then, apart from the Congress party.

“The Central government gave us compensation of Rs 4.5 lakhs. The then Gujarat government has given Rs 5 lakh and

the Congress party gave us compensation of Rs 1 lakh,” he said.

“Even if it was delayed, the important thing is justice has been delivered,” says Vijay Modi, whose mother, then 55-years old, was a vendor in the Sarangpur marketplace and suffered a leg injury. Bombs had gone off in several public places, including Sarangpur, Khadia, Raipur and Isanpur, in addition to the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital and the municipal corporation-run LG Hospital. “My mother was treated at VS hospital,” says Vijay Modi, adding that she died in 2016.

As an 18-year-old boy at the

time, Darshan Modi remembers how panic had struck their neighbourhood in the Khadia area of the Walled City that Saturday. “My mother had gone to the market in Sarangpur to buy vegetables and we heard about the blasts. There was chaos. She was bleeding on one leg and the doctors told us she had been hit by shrapnel. ““We are lucky that she survived... It must be tough for those who lost their loved ones,” says Darshan Modi, now an IT professional. His mother, now 58 years old, lives abroad with his brother.

“I think the High Court verdict is very fair,” he says.



On ethanol, make haste slowly

THE CENTRE is apparently going slow on implementing ethanol blending in petrol beyond the current 20 per cent. The rethink, as reported by this newspaper, comes even as the Finance Ministry, only last month, exempted petrol containing 22, 25, 27 and 30 per cent ethanol from excise duty after the Bureau of Indian Standards had issued specifications for these higher blends. The move to not hurry the transition to 20 per cent-plus blends makes sense. The all-India average ethanol-petrol blending ratio rose from 5 to 10 per cent between 2019-20 and 2021-22. It has since further doubled to 20 per cent, with this blend (E20) being made mandatory for all petrol sold from April 2026. Given how fast it has happened — well before the originally planned 2030 deadline — a pause isn't a bad thing from a policy or practical standpoint.

The pause period should be used by the government to address genuine concerns of motorists. The first has to do with lower mileage because of ethanol's calorific value being 30-35 per cent less compared to that of pure petrol. The second is on account of ethanol's hygroscopic (moisture-absorbing) property, which can lead to corrosion of steel fuel tanks and internal metal components. As it is, only vehicles sold in India after April 2023 have full material compatibility with E20. Handling fuel with ethanol blends may require major overhaul of internal combustion engines and auto parts to resist any potential ethanol-related degradation. Not surprisingly, it's the older car and two-wheeler owners who are feeling short-changed; reduced mileage and wearing of engine parts from ethanol is something they were not told about at the time of purchase before April 2023. All the more reason for transparent communication before embarking on E25 or E30. The government can even consider fiscal measures that would make the higher ethanol-blended fuels cheaper than E20, which will make consumers more receptive to them.

That said, the focus on biofuels and electrification of transport must continue. The risks of 90 per cent crude petroleum import dependency are too high — and the Iran war will not be the last of the global oil supply shocks. India needs a clear, calibrated and forward-looking roadmap for higher ethanol blends that avoid the abruptness of the earlier rollouts. Equally important is the feedstock for producing ethanol. It's certainly not desirable to make ethanol from water-guzzling rice. More effort is required to promote sweet sorghum, bajra and other millets as sustainable feedstocks, with breeding of varieties/hybrids with higher starch content and fermentation efficiencies comparable to maize or sugarcane.

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The safety net and the trade-off

IN RECENT years, several states have introduced cash transfer schemes aimed at women. From the Ladli Behna Yojana in Madhya Pradesh to the Maiya Samman Yojana in Jharkhand and the Magalir Urimai Thogai scheme in Tamil Nadu, these typically involve transfers in the range of Rs 1,000 to Rs 2,500 per month. The quantum of funds channelled through these schemes has increased significantly. In 2025-26, 12 states were estimated to spend Rs 1.68 lakh crore on unconditional cash transfers, as per a report by PRS Legislative Research. To put this in perspective — the Union government allocated Rs 86,000 crore for the MGNREGA in 2025-26.

Unconditional cash transfers have emerged as an instrument of social welfare and empowerment for women, and as an electoral strategy for political parties. A new study — 'Unconditional Women Cash Transfer Programmes in India', EAC-PM Working Paper Series — provides evidence to support these. Examining such schemes in Maharashtra and Odisha, it finds that they have led to improvements in consumption and savings of beneficiaries, raising household welfare, with more being allocated for medical, educational and lifestyle purposes. These are welcome trends, and underline the reasons for the spread of such schemes.

Over the last few years, however, concerns have been expressed that as states allocate more resources for such schemes and populist measures such as free electricity, their ability to spend on other areas gets affected. The central bank has echoed these concerns, saying that they "run the risk of crowding out" investments. This shift to cash transfers has also come at a time of mounting disquiet over state finances. As per a report from Axis Bank, the resources for these schemes are garnered through expenditure switching and higher deficits. While the consolidated debt of states has fallen from 31 per cent in March 2021 to 29.2 per cent in 2026 (budget estimates), there is a marked variation across states. For instance, Punjab has a debt burden of 46.4 per cent of the GSDP, West Bengal 38.9 per cent and Bihar 36.8 per cent. "High debt levels, growing contingent liabilities from guarantees and cash transfer schemes pose risks to state finances," the RBI noted. This requires closer attention.



RAJA MANDALA

BY C RAJA MOHAN

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's eastward journey this week — from Indonesia to Australia and New Zealand — marks the consolidation of a new Indo-Pacific approach that might be called "G Minus Two". The idea of a US-China condominium in Asia has always made Indian strategists uneasy. President Donald Trump's occasional references to a G2, along with his administration's decision to discard the Indo-Pacific terminology, have reinforced those anxieties.

Delhi is responding to the new dynamic between Washington and Beijing by expanding its cooperation with the rest of Asia. This is similar to the ways in which several Asian powers are dealing with the changes in US-China relations. The unfolding Asian pattern of "G Minus Two" should help shift India's Indo-Pacific debate away from sterile slogans about American intentions or Chinese ambitions. The more practical question is what India can build with the rest of Asia.

The visits to Delhi by Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi this month and South Korean President Lee Jae-myung in April underlined the urgency in Tokyo and Seoul, two key Asian allies of Washington, to widen their Asian ties. Modi's visits to Jakarta, Melbourne and Auckland point to the same logic — the im-

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portance of expanding the geopolitical room for manoeuvre by strengthening cooperation among themselves.

"G Minus Two" is not about Asia turning its back on America. Quite the contrary. Most Asian countries recognise that there can be no stable balance of power in Asia without a sustained US strategic presence. China's rising military weight cannot be balanced by the rest of Asia, even if they act in concert. That is why Japan, South Korea, Australia and New Zealand continue to build on their security partnerships with Washington. If anything, uncertainty under Trump has increased the incentive to bind the US more closely to Asian security.

India and Indonesia, despite their non-aligned tradition, have reached similar conclusions. As China flexes its military muscle, both have intensified defence cooperation with the US. Their "strategic autonomy" under China's shadow rests not on keeping America at arm's length, but on working with it and navigating Trump's mercurial diplomacy. Both Delhi and Jakarta are now "major defence partners" of Washington.

If "G Minus Two" is not about distancing from the US, neither is it about containing China. Every major Asian nation, including India and the three countries Modi is visiting this week, knows that Chinese power in Asia and the Indo-Pacific is a reality that must be managed. They also have to deal with the extraordinary economic interdependence with China.

The Asian objective is to "de-risk" Beijing's weaponisation of interdependence. India's annual trade with China is now at \$150 billion. Comparable figures for America's Asian partners underline the same reality: South Korea

Every major Asian nation, including India and the three countries Modi is visiting this week, knows that Chinese power in Asia and the Indo-Pacific is a reality that must be managed

trades roughly \$300 billion with China, Japan more than \$300 billion, Australia over \$200 billion, while ASEAN's trade with China has crossed the trillion-dollar mark. Commercial decoupling is not a realistic option. The Asian imperative for deeper economic cooperation among the regional powers has been reinforced by Trump's tariff wars. This logic was evident during President Lee's visit, which emphasised strategic economic cooperation, and during PM Takaichi's visit, which expanded the agenda on economic security. Similar themes of economic resilience and defence cooperation will dominate Modi's discussions in Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand.

The objective is neither an anti-China coalition nor an alternative to the American alliance system. Nor is it an attempt to create an independent bloc of middle powers. It is a practical effort to strengthen India's partnerships with the major industrial, technological and maritime powers of Asia.

Japan brings advanced manufacturing, defence technology and infrastructure finance. South Korea offers world-class capabilities in shipbuilding, semiconductors and defence production. Australia has become indispensable in critical minerals, maritime security and the stabilisation of the eastern Indian Ocean. New Zealand offers important opportunities in trade, higher education, agriculture and advanced technologies.

Whether Washington uses the term Indo-Pacific or not, Indonesia remains the geographical and geopolitical heart of that concept. Sitting astride the confluence of the Indian and Pacific Oceans, it occupies one of the most consequential strategic locations in the world.

Greater economic integration between two of Asia's largest markets and deeper security cooperation between Delhi and Jakarta have long been missing links in the regional search for peace and prosperity.

Taken individually, India's partnerships with Japan, South Korea, Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand each advance important national interests. Collectively, however, they create something larger. They widen the strategic space available to all these countries between the US and China.

That is the essence of "G Minus Two". Asia now has a remarkably capable group of industrial, technological and maritime powers. Together, they account for a substantial share of global manufacturing, innovation, shipping and trade. Their mutual cooperation cannot replace either Washington or Beijing. It can, however, widen Asia's strategic horizons beyond the constricting imagery of a G2 world.

Ultimately, the success of India's "G Minus Two" will depend less on Modi's summit diplomacy than on India's own urgency for internal economic reform and defence modernisation. The more competitive India's economy becomes, and the stronger its defence industrial base grows, the deeper its partnerships with the rest of Asia can be. That, more than the endless speculation about US-China relations and their consequences, will determine India's place in the emerging Asian order.

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SUSAN THOMAS
AND CHIRASHREE GHOSH

To ensure a quality creche is the employer’s job

ON JULY 1, Capgemini shut down its on-campus daycare in Bengaluru after viral videos allegedly showing toddlers being abused surfaced. The shocking allegations are a warning about a larger childcare system that remains underregulated, undervalued, and often invisible. The Capgemini episode is a symptom of a much deeper crisis: The urgent need to build a safe, accountable, and dignified childcare ecosystem.

A robust childcare system will ensure children grow in a secure, nurturing, and developmentally rich environment. It enables women to enter and stay in the workforce. It converts care work from an invisible burden into a formal profession with standards, training, and fair wages. Despite rapid progress, 86 million children under six still lack access to quality early care at the very age when 85 per cent of brain development is most rapid. At the same time, female labour force participation remains distressingly low, especially in urban India where mothers are often forced to choose between earning and caregiving. This is not only a social problem; it is a drag on productivity, economic growth, and inclusion.

Other countries have shown that childcare is not a peripheral welfare scheme but core infrastructure. Singapore, for instance, expanded preschool capacity, subsidised centres, and tightened safety and wage standards as part of a strategy to support working families and national productivity.

This calls for the expansion of childcare services, crèches, maternity and parental benefits, skilling of childcare workers, and family-friendly workplace policies to reduce women’s unpaid care burden

India has a legal framework that recognises the importance of workplace crèches. The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017 and the related crèche guidelines set out standards for staffing, monitoring, safety, and training. However, it is important to implement the guidelines to avoid such tragedies. What requires proactive action is responding to the needs of women workers in the formal and informal sector.

A crèche is not a convenience room where children are merely supervised until parents finish work. It is a space where nutrition, health, safety, early learning, and emotional well-being must come together. Children need more than watchfulness; they need responsive care from trained adults.

Childcare is still treated as a low-status extension of unpaid domestic labour. Workers are paid meagre wages, and their skilling is not a priority. This calls for the expansion of childcare services, crèches, maternity and parental benefits, skilling of childcare workers, and family-friendly workplace policies to reduce women’s unpaid care burden. Such measures enable women to participate equally in economic, social, and political life while ensuring the well-being and development of

children. This will facilitate the delivery of a triple dividend through childcare.

As we rapidly move towards Viksit Bharat, childcare must be treated as essential public infrastructure. That means moving from voluntary compliance to strict enforcement. Crèche Monitoring Committees must function properly, with parent participation, regular checks, and unannounced audits. Safety standards must be monitored, not merely announced. Employers must be held accountable for the quality of care provided.

Just as important, the childcare workforce must be professionalised. Caring for young children requires training in child development, nutrition, hygiene, behaviour, and first response in emergencies. Certification, decent pay, and career pathways are the foundation of quality care.

The Bengaluru case should not fade into the usual cycle of outrage and forgetfulness. It should force a national reckoning to move towards a collective solution. It cannot be an afterthought that every child deserves safety, stimulation, and dignity. Every parent deserves confidence that their child is in capable hands. And every economy that hopes to prosper must recognise that care is not a private burden to be absorbed silently by women. It is public infrastructure, and it belongs at the centre of national development.

Thomas is committee member, and Ghosh is national coordinator, FORCES

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U.S. PRESIDENT RENEWS PUSH TO CONTROL GREENLAND

NATO flaunts arms deals as Trump targets Europe allies

Key 'defence forum' yields \$50 billion in deals: NATO official

Reuters
Ankara, July 7

NATO LEADERS unveiled arms deals worth tens of billions of dollars in Turkey on Tuesday, driving home the message that they are heeding US calls to spend more to defend Europe even as President Donald Trump said he felt let down and renewed his push to control Greenland.

Leaders were convening for a summit in the capital Ankara, hoping to project unity after another bruising year, in which the Iran war once again exposed cracks in the alliance.

In a meeting with President Tayyip Erdogan, Trump said he might have boycotted the NATO summit altogether had it not been for his warm relations with Turkish leader, and did not rule out further troop withdrawals from Europe. “Well, we’re going to see. I was very disappointed with NATO,” he said, singling out Britain, France, Germany and Italy for not doing enough to support US war on Iran.

Trump added “we weren’t treated well” by the allies, even as he reiterated that he did not want or need their help. “Before I asked, they said they wouldn’t be there, and we’ve invested trillions of dollars in NATO,” Trump said.

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US President Donald Trump with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan in Ankara on Tuesday. AP

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NATO members have repeatedly tried to show Trump that they are stepping up. NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte said on Monday Europeans had made “staggering”

Before Trump's arrival, Rutte trumpeted a series of initiatives and deals at a defence industry forum, and called for a defence industry "revolution" across the alliance, warning over Russia's massive military spending as well as China, North Korea and Iran.

“We don’t have the luxury of time. We need capabilities now to ensure we remain ready. The security situation demands it,” Rutte said. “The hum of machinery must become a roar.”

The deals, estimated to be worth at least \$50 billion ac-

cording to one NATO official, included European countries buying surveillance drones from US company Northrop Grumman, and NATO buying planes from Sweden's Saab.

Europe's defence sector has often been criticised as fragmented and saddled with red tape and rivalries between companies and countries. That has left Europe more reliant on purchases of US weapons.

Tensions within NATO, already strained over Ukraine and Trump's desire to wrest Greenland from fellow NATO member Denmark, have deepened since the US attacked Iran in February.

On Tuesday, he renewed his push to wrest Greenland from Denmark. "That should be controlled by the United States, not by Denmark," he said.

Trump: US to lift Turkey sanctions, sell F-35 fighters

Reuters
Ankara, July 7

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Tuesday announced that the US would lift sanctions on Turkey that were imposed in 2020 over Ankara's purchase of Russian missiles, and signaled a willingness to sell the NATO ally F-35 fighter jets, moves that would both be massive gestures to Turkey but may face legal hurdles.

In the first visit to Turkey by a US President in 11 years, Trump was welcomed by President Tayyip Erdogan at the airport with a lavish state ceremony.

Speaking to reporters at the Turkish presidential palace, Trump repeatedly praised Erdogan, saying he had "chemistry" with him and that the relationship with Ankara has never been better.

Turkey's 2019 acquisition of a Russian S-400 system and Washington's 2020 imposition of sanctions on a major Turkish defence company and removal of Turkey from the F-35 stealth fighter jet program have long been a sore point. "We're going to be taking the sanctions off," Trump said. "It's time. We don't want to sanction friends."

When asked if he had any concerns about Ankara still being in possession of the Russian S-400s, he said he did not.

LNG tanker at risk of exploding after two ships hit; Iran blamed

Reuters
Doha, July 7

A QATARI LNG tanker was at risk of exploding and a Saudi-flagged crude oil tanker was damaged near the Strait of Hormuz, sources said Tuesday, after reports Iran fired missiles at ships in the waterway overnight.

The *Al Rekayyat*, loaded with liquefied natural gas, sent out distress signals seeking assistance after it was hit on its port side, one of the sources said. Another source briefed on the matter said the vessel was at risk of exploding due to a fire in its engine room. The crew were safe and were being evacuated.

It is the first time an LNG ship from Qatar, a mediator in talks between Washington and Tehran, has been struck since the start of the Iran war.

A Saudi-flagged tanker, believed to be the supertanker Wedyan, was also damaged off Oman's coast, maritime security sources said. The cause

was not immediately known.

Al Rekayyat is owned and managed by Nakilat, also known as Qatar Gas Transport Company Ltd, which operates one of the world's largest LNG shipping fleets. LSEG shipping data showed the vessel last transmitted its location on June 18, indicating its AIS tracking transponder was switched off.

Wedyan is owned and managed by Saudi shipping firm Bahri. Bahri, Nakilat, QatarEnergy, Qatar's international media office, the Saudi government's media office and US Central Command did not respond to requests for comment.

There was no claim of responsibility for the attacks. A US official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said initial indications were that Iran had fired at two commercial vessels.

Qatar's foreign ministry said Tehran bore full legal responsibility for the attack on the LNG tanker. Tehran did not immediately comment.

NBFCs' GOLD LOAN OUTSTANDING HAS RISEN 136% IN THE LAST TWO YEARS

Jewellery-backed loans soar 70%, lead NBFC retail credit growth

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 7

GOLD LOANS are glittering as never before, driving a surge in credit growth for non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) and emerging as the fastest-growing segment of retail credit amid high gold prices.

Outstanding NBFC loans against gold jewellery surged by 69.9% year-on-year to Rs 3.29 lakh crore by the end of May 2026 from Rs 1.94 lakh in May 2025, far outpacing the 19.5% growth in overall retail loans, according to the latest Reserve Bank of India data.

Gold loan outstanding of NBFC players has jumped by 136% from Rs 1.4 lakh crore in the last two years.

As a result, gold loans by NBFCs accounted for a much larger share of retail credit, reflecting increased borrower preference for secured lending backed by rising gold prices.

“In a country where household gold holdings are significant, the rapid growth of gold loans is enabling households to convert a traditionally held asset into a source of accessible finance. This is supporting greater financial inclusion while enabling consumers to meet a wide range of personal and livelihood needs,” said Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

Manish Jain, Country Managing Director of Experian India. The growth story is also becoming increasingly broad-based across the country.

While Southern India continues to remain an important market for gold loans, strong sourcing growth in FY26 was seen in states such as Uttar Pradesh (138%), West Bengal (112%), Rajasthan (105%) and Maharashtra (102%), highlighting growing acceptance of gold-backed lending beyond its traditional regional concentration and indicating a broader pan-India expansion trend, Experian said.

There is evidence that gold loans are becoming an increasingly important gateway to formal credit for a wider spectrum of consumers. By unlocking the value of household gold, priority sector gold loans are helping convert dormant assets into productive capital, especially supporting women-led households, micro-enterprises, livelihood generation and greater participation in the formal financial ecosystem.

While companies have not yet reported any signs of stress in the segment, the practice of rolling over gold loans by making partial payments to extend the tenure and reset the loan period has become widespread.

• NBFC LOAN GROWTH DRIVERS

THE GROWTH story is increasingly becoming broad-based. Loans against gold jewellery surged by 138% in Uttar Pradesh, in West Bengal it rose by 112%, in Rajasthan by 105% and in Maharashtra at 102%.

IT HIGHLIGHTS growing acceptance of gold-backed lending beyond its traditional regional concentration.

COMMERCIAL REAL estate also emerged as the one of fastest-



growing mainstream categories in credit growth with outstanding credit to the segment surging 40.2% to Rs 1.196 lakh crore in May 2026 from Rs 85,317 cr a year ago.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 However, latest RBI guidelines have placed strict limits on such rollovers.

Borrowers are now required to fully repay bullet loans within 12 months, and lenders are barred from “evergreening” loans by repeatedly extending the tenure without conducting fresh appraisals, said an industry player. Muthoot Finance, the largest player in the segment, reported Rs 1.65 lakh crore worth of gold loans and 196 tonnes of gold as security from customers in FY26.

The industry portfolio, including banks, also expanded substantially from Rs 6.3 lakh

Retail loans accounted for the biggest share in non-banks’ loans at 43%, with gold loans — which are part of retail loans — making up 5.6% of all loans as at the end of May. Loans to industry had a share of 37.4%, with that of services at 13%.

Real estate loans spurt by 40.2%

Commercial real estate has emerged as the one of fastest-growing mainstream categories in credit growth in the

NBFC sector with outstanding credit to the segment surging 40.2% year-on-year to Rs 1.196 lakh crore in May 2026 from Rs 85,317 crore a year ago, significantly outpacing the 10.2% growth recorded in May 2025, data released by the RBI on Tuesday shows.

The sharp rise suggests stronger financing activity for commercial property projects amid improving demand in office, warehousing and mixed-use developments.

The spike has also raised concern as credit to commercial real estate is considered as a risky segment along with unsecured retail lending and microfinance lending, according to an official of a nationalised bank.

Overall, NBFCs, including housing finance companies (HFCs), continued to expand credit at a healthy pace in May 2026, with outstanding loans rising 14.2% to Rs 58.61 lakh crore from Rs 51.32 lakh crore a year earlier, RBI data shows.

Bank credit to NBFCs rose 33.7% year-on-year to around Rs 20.88 lakh crore by May 2026. This has improved NBFCs’ ability to extend loans to sectors where they have enjoyed a competitive edge, including commercial real estate.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

has indeed been extraordinary. personal loans and gold loans.” This The public’s increased will.

India flags flaws in US’ Section 301 tariff probe

Mukesh Jagota
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA HAS flagged several flaws in the way the US has initiated and conducted its investigation into alleged forced-labour content in Indian imports. It also suggested bilateral dialogue to address any specific concern of the US in this regard.

In its formal response to the Report in Section 301 investigations on imports of goods with forced labour that has proposed 12.5% additional tariffs on India, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry has said the office of US Trade Representative (USTR) has issued a sweeping, generalised determination across 60 economies without performing an economy-specific, or product-specific analysis of India’s actual laws and practices.

The USTR probe covers 60 economies, including the European Union (EU). India has also sought reconsideration of the proposed tariffs.

Separately, the USTR is investigating India, the EU, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, South Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Japan over policies that allegedly enable excess manufacturing capacity



The USTR probe covers 60 economies, including EU. REUTERS

and undermine the US industrial base. The findings could pave the way for another round of additional tariffs.

The investigations are seen as part of Washington’s efforts to rebuild its tariff architecture following the US Supreme Court’s verdict on reciprocal tariffs. The Section 301 investigations are also part of the ongoing India-US trade agreement negotiations.

Public hearings on the forced-labour investigation begin on Tuesday, with the Indian government and industry scheduled to present their arguments on Wednesday.

India argued that the USTR has failed to meet the legal threshold under Section 301(d) of the Trade Act by concluding that India’s acts, policies or practices relating to imports are unreasonable. FE

ECLGS 5.0 sanctions cross Rs 1.55 lakh cr within 2 months of launch

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 7

THE CENTRAL government has issued guarantees worth Rs 1.55 lakh crore under the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) 5.0 within two months of its launch, reflecting the scheme’s rapid absorption across the lending ecosystem.

Approved by the Union Cabinet on May 5, 2026, the scheme has issued 4,11,497 guarantees so far.

MSMEs (micro, small, and medium enterprises) account for 98% of all guarantees issued (by number), and 82% of the total guaranteed amount is also towards MSMEs, the government data showed.

The scheme aims to facilitate additional credit of Rs 2.55

lakh crore to existing borrowers by March 2027.

By extending 100% guarantee coverage to additional loans of MSMEs and 90% to other business segments, the scheme has allowed financial institutions to lend more confidently, ensuring liquidity reaches the needy sectors.

The scheme provides 100% guarantee coverage for MSMEs and 90% for non-MSMEs, to facilitate additional credit of Rs 2.55 lakh crore to existing borrowers.

Wide participation by banks and non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), customer outreach initiatives, and government-led awareness programmes have contributed to its swift uptake across sectors. The results from ECLGS 5.0 reflect the government’s

continued commitment to building a resilient, responsive credit ecosystem. As the scheme evolves and outreach expands, it is expected to further strengthen liquidity support for businesses including MSMEs and enable entrepreneurs to meet their liquidity needs in the times of external challenges.

To maximise awareness and adoption, the Department of Financial Services (DFS) has led a structured outreach campaign across the country.

These outreach programmes are intended to ensure that eligible borrowers are aware of the Scheme and are able to access its benefits, while Member Lending Institutions (MLIs) are equipped to facilitate its effective implementation. FE

New Delhi